My cousin Sanjay was at Clement Town, married to Dipti, our neighbour from SO Flats, Chanakyapuri days, and they had an adorable two-year-old daughter, Tarini. On most Sundays, I would cycle down to their house, where we would have a glass of beer and then a delicious meal, mostly non-vegetarian. After a siesta, we would all climb on to his bike and go for long rides through the back trails, or up to Mohand Pass. After an early dinner, I would then cycle back in the dark, torch in one hand, pedalling furiously away so as not to be late for the final head count, which was at 2200 hours. One day, towards the middle of the third term, Sanjay asked me what (branch) I was opting for. I knew that I was going to opt for the Infantry but confided that I knew little of the various Regiments that comprise the Infantry. Sanjay said that I should opt for his, i.e. the Mahar Regiment, and that he knew the Aide de Camp (ADC) to Gen KV Krishna Rao, who was tipped to become the next Chief. He (the ADC) would ensure that I get his Battalion too, namely 6 MAHAR. To clinch his argument, he added, '*Donon field mein baith ke daru piyenge*' (we'll both sit in the field, i.e. on the borders, and drink). I thought that it was logical and did indeed opt for Infantry/ Mahar as my first choice in the Choice of Arms held a few weeks later. My second choice was the Rajputana Rifles, on account of their Regimental Centre being in Delhi, as I thought it would give me another opportunity to spend some time with Veena and her friends. This is how momentous career choices are made. As luck would have it, though I did get Infantry, I got neither of my choices—Mahar, Rajputana Rifles or Garhwal Rifles. The last was on account of Capt S Trikha of 3 GARH RIF, my Platoon Commander in Alamein who was very fond of me, being the only Infantry optee in his whole Platoon.

Capt Trikha had a strange way of showing his appreciation. In all the exercises and camps, the GCs are given exercise

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